

De Stijl

Originating in the Netherlands with Piet Mondrian (1872–1944) and Theo Van Doesburg (1883–1931), De Stijl ('the style') sought to create the ideal fusion of form and function, a reduction of elements to create harmony and order, in the wake of the First World War. Adopting the visual elements of cubism and constructivism, as well as the mystical geometric principles of mathematician M.H.J. Schoenmaekers (1875–1944), it aimed for a new aesthetic that would encompass all the arts, including painting, architecture, urban planning, industrial design, typography, music and poetry. In architecture, De Stijl helped to instigate the international style of the 1920s and 1930s and had a marked influence on the more revolutionary architects, including Mies van der Rohe and Le Corbusier. Architect members of the group included Rietveld, whose Schröder House (opposite, 1924) in Utrecht was the only building completed to pure De Stijl principles, and J.J.P. Oud (1890–1963), whose 1925 Café De Unie in Rotterdam features rectangular planes in primary colours and white plaster, like a giant Mondrian painting.

